brows was that the toppers had chosen the same 'wrong' options in their exam that the ESB had erroneously marked in its answer key. It was only after a major hue and cry was raised that the questions were withdrawn. Separately, an interview of one of the toppers, Poonam Rajawat, has also gone viral. In the interview, conducted by *The Lallantop*, Rajawat failed to answer a few basic questions related to the test and was even unable to name its eight subjects.

Political mudslinging ensued soon after these issues were flagged. Fake videos of candidates are doing the rounds on social media, claiming that they had been offered selection in exchange for money. While the BJP has accused the Congress of spreading the fake clips, the fact of "too many coincidences" is what the opposition party is citing. "Changing the name of the body that conducts exams from Vyapam to ESB has not changed anything on the ground," said former MP Arun Yadav. Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, too, said on Twitter, "The BJP has just stolen from the youths of Madhya Pradesh. The Patwari examination scam is Vyapam 2.0 scam, which is playing with the future of lakhs of young people."

A VIDEO INTERVIEW OF ONE OF THE TOPPERS SHOWED HER FAILING TO ANSWER EVEN BASIC QUESTIONS, SUCH AS THE TEST'S SUBJECTS

Initially, the top officials at the ESB had denied any discrepancies. The government, too, issued a clarification stating that the ten toppers took the exam on different dates. It also said six of them signed their exam sheets in Hindi, and none of them secured the full 25 marks in English, as Congress leaders were claiming. The toppers, in fact, had scored between 13 and 23 marks in English, it added. Also, of the 78 centres where the exams were held between March 15 and April 26, the NRI college, the government said, accounted for only about 114 selections, while other centres had selections ranging from 29 to 321 candidates each.

These explanations, however, have cut little ice with those questioning the test's fairness. On July 13, Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan, perhaps sensing that the issue might snowball further, decided to hit pause on recruitments. The state also recently ordered a judicial inquiry led by retired high court judge Rajendra Verma, who has been asked to submit a detailed report by August 31. Meanwhile, candidates continue to demand that recruitments be done in a time-bound manner.

This is not the first time Madhya Pradesh has made headlines due to such scams. In 2020, rigging allegations surfaced during the agriculture extension officer entrance test too, also organised by the ESB. The results of the test were eventually cancelled. In the same year, it was discovered that the state nursing council had recognised several 'ghost' nursing colleges that existed only on paper. Meanwhile, the CBI inquiry into the original Vyapam scandal continues apace, and numerous convictions have been made in the case since it broke.

What turn this latest controversy takes will depend on several factors, though the ruling BJP can be sure that the timing is something that's certainly not going to make things easy for it. ■

By Rohit Parihar

Rajasthan is on the BJP's mind. That's clear enough from the way the high command is itself taking charge of matters in the poll-bound state. But even the flurry of organisational steps it has announced leave untouched a certain vacuum at the heart of its strategy: the question of leadership. While circling indecisively around that, the party is doing everything it can to prevent Congress chief minister Ashok Gehlot from winning a nearly unprecedented re-election later this year. On July 16, BJP president J.P. Nadda addressed a workers' rally in Jaipur, his second in less than three weeks. Within that same duration, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union home minister Amit Shah and BJP national general secretary B.L. Santhosh touched base in Bikaner, Udaipur and Sawai Madhopur respectively for public and party events.

The avoidance of the leadership question shows in how the party is falling back on its organisational matrix. Though many attribute the BJP's loss in Karnataka to Santhosh's strategy, it hasn't stopped the high command from placing him at the forefront in Rajasthan. Union parliamentary affairs minister Pralhad Joshi, another organisation man, has been made state election in-charge. Former Gujarat deputy chief minister Nitin Patel, who'll have a hotline to Shah, is a co-in-charge; so is Kuldeep Bishnoi, the son of late Haryana CM Bhajan Lal who only joined the BJP last year but whose caste base has an overlap with Rajasthan. Also, Rajya Sabha MP Kirodi Lal Meena has been included in the national working committee along with deputy leader of the Opposition Satish Poonia, the man C.P. Joshi replaced as state chief.

Alongside, the BJP is setting the tone and tempo for the electoral contest in December: taking on the Gehlot government is naturally front and centre of its strategy. A taunting jingle, '*Gehlot ji, koni mile vote ji*' (Gehlot ji, you won't get the votes), will soon hit the airwaves. If the slogan '*Nahin sahega Rajasthan*' (Rajasthan won't tolerate) was trending on social media when Nadda addressed the Jaipur rally, Modi modified a Rahul Gandhi line to call the Congress regime a '*Loot ki dukaan, jhooth ka bazaar*' (a shop for loot, a marketplace of lies) during his July 8 rally in Bikaner.

Incidentally, that rally was his seventh in Rajasthan in nine months. Each was held in a different region. In tandem with a development push, this was meant to account for